Student Movement Wins Big Election in Serbia

From: PBS NewsHour Mined: 2026-10-27 3 min read

Big election news came from Serbia this weekend. Serbia is a small country in southeastern Europe with under seven million people. Its longtime leader, Aleksandar Vucic, lost a historic election on Sunday, and his government fell.

What makes this win special, experts say, is who led it: students. The movement had no single leader. It was spread out, not run from the top, and it used online tools to organize.

The protesters' main focus was **corruption** in government. Vucic had once served in the **cabinet** of Slobodan Milosevic, a former Serbian leader. The win follows a recent election in Hungary that also fought **corruption**, and it is seen as a **setback** for Russia and China.

This was not a race against one rival. In a **parliamentary** election, voters choose parties, not a single president. When polls showed his party losing badly, Vucic admitted defeat peacefully, which surprised **observers**.

The big question now is what comes next. If the student-led movement cannot form a government, Vucic's side could fight another day.

Word Treasure

corruption -- When people in power use their power in a dishonest way for themselves.
parliamentary -- About an election where voters choose parties, not one single leader.
cabinet -- A group of top leaders who help run a government.
setback -- Something that slows down or holds back a plan or a side.
observers -- People who watch an event closely to see what happens.

Background you need

Serbia is a small country in southeastern Europe where voters choose parties in a parliamentary election.

Corruption means dishonest use of power in government, and it was the main focus of the protesters.

The student movement had no single leader and used online tools to organize, and it now faces the hard job of trying to form a government.

Break it down

WHO: Students leading a spread-out movement, and longtime leader Aleksandar Vucic, whose government fell.
WHAT: A parliamentary election ended with Vucic's government falling after his party lost badly in the polls.
WHERE: Serbia, a small country in southeastern Europe.
WHY: The protesters focused on corruption in government.

Why it matters

Even as a student, you can see how working together with others can make a real difference in your community.

Test what you remember

1. What country is this story about?

(A) Russia
(B) China
(C) Serbia
(D) Hungary

2. Who led the movement that won?

(A) Observers
(B) Students
(C) Slobodan Milosevic
(D) Aleksandar Vucic

3. What was the protesters' main focus?

(A) One leader running everything
(B) Corruption in government
(C) A race against one rival
(D) Serving in a cabinet

4. In a parliamentary election, what do voters choose?

(A) A single leader
(B) A single president
(C) One rival
(D) Parties

5. How did the movement organize?

(A) Through one single leader
(B) By choosing a president
(C) With online tools
(D) From the top down

6. What is the big question now?

(A) Whether polls showed Vucic winning
(B) Whether Hungary fought corruption
(C) Whether Serbia is in southeastern Europe
(D) Whether the student-led movement can form a government

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: B 4: D 5: C 6: D

Questions to think about

1. **Experts: They say what makes the win special is that students led it.**
2. **Observers: They were surprised that Vucic admitted defeat peacefully.**

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):